

THE SCRAMBLE FOR Africa

COLONIAL AFRICA

The phrase “Scramble for Africa” refers to the rapid colonization of the continent by European powers during the 19th and 20th centuries. An often-cited justification for the so-called “scramble” was to end the African slave trade, but European explorers also took the opportunity to exploit Africa’s natural resources. Missionary-explorer David

Livingstone claimed that the only way to “liberate” the people of the African continent was to introduce the “three C’s”—commerce, civilization, and Christianity.

European missionaries, many of whom were nuns and lay women, played an ambiguous role in this endeavor. They were driven by a genuine desire to improve the

► Enslaving the continent

Women, who traditionally perform horticultural work in many African countries, labor on a state banana plantation in Irebu Camp in the Belgian Congo, c.1900-1910.

